A Product Thinking Case Study

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A. The Product You Chose

- ### What is the product?

Vantage Circle's Recognition & Rewards (R&R) Platform is a SaaS solution that enables continuous, real-time, and visible employee recognition within organizations.

- ### Why did I choose this product?

I currently work at Vantage Circle as a Business Analyst and aspire to grow into a Product Manager role. I spend a significant amount of time using the Rewards and Recognition platform, giving me deep firsthand experience with its strengths and pain points. This product is close to my professional journey, and I am passionate about leveraging my insights to drive meaningful impact for organizations and employees.

B. Product Vision

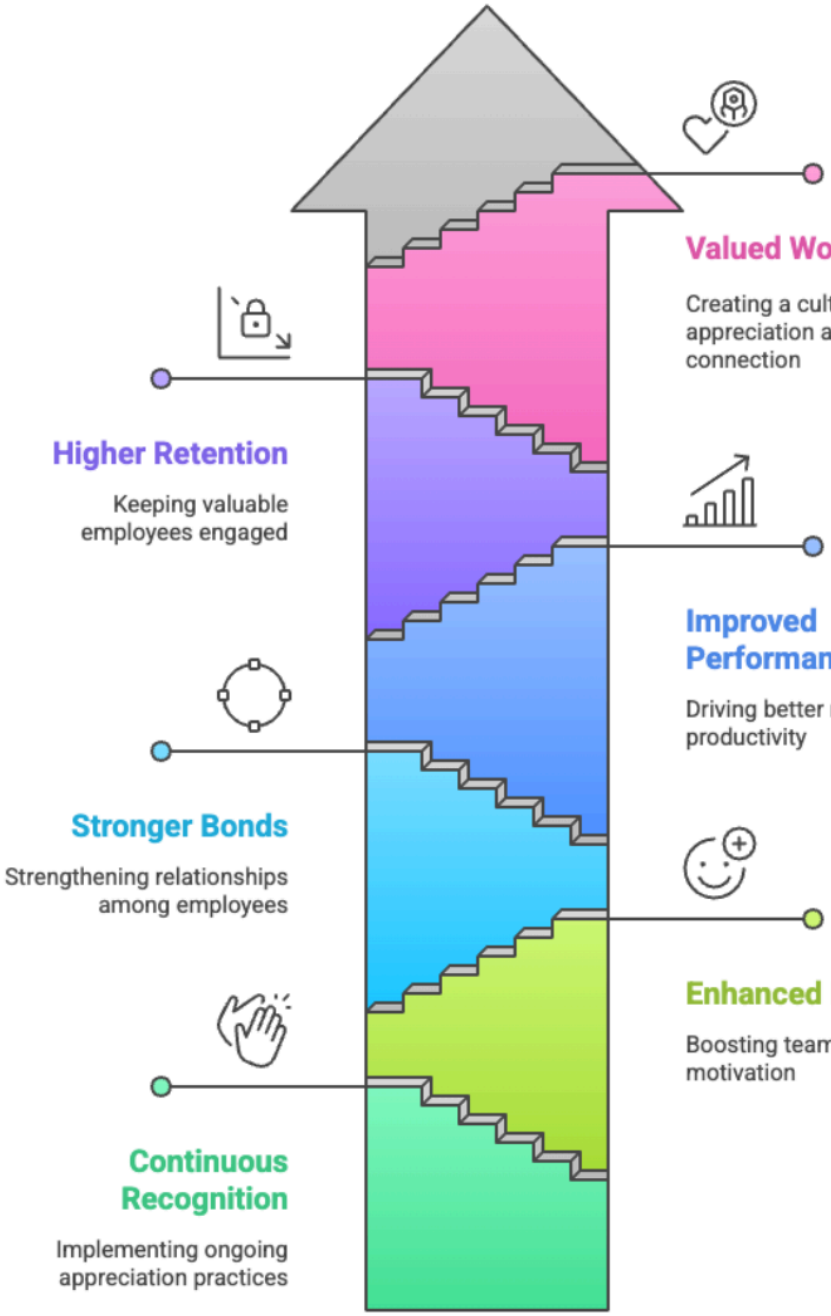
- **One line to summarize:**

"To create a world where every employee feels valued, motivated, and connected through continuous and meaningful recognition, transforming workplace culture and performance at scale."

Imagine a workplace where every person, regardless of their role or seniority, feels genuinely valued and motivated every single day. In this world, appreciation is not an afterthought or a quarterly ritual, but a natural, ongoing part of how people work together. Recognition flows freely and instantly, connecting teams and individuals, boosting morale, and strengthening the bonds that make organizations thrive.

Our vision is to make this a reality by transforming recognition from a rare event into a continuous, meaningful experience.
We want to build a platform where every employee's effort is noticed, celebrated, and amplified—creating a ripple effect of positivity and engagement throughout the organization. Over time, this will not only make people happier at work, but will also drive better performance, higher retention, and a culture where everyone feels truly connected.

Achieving a Valued Workplace



Valued Workplace

Creating a culture of appreciation and connection

Higher Retention

Keeping valuable employees engaged

Improved Performance

Driving better results and productivity

Stronger Bonds

Strengthening relationships among employees

Enhanced Morale

Boosting team spirit and motivation

Continuous Recognition

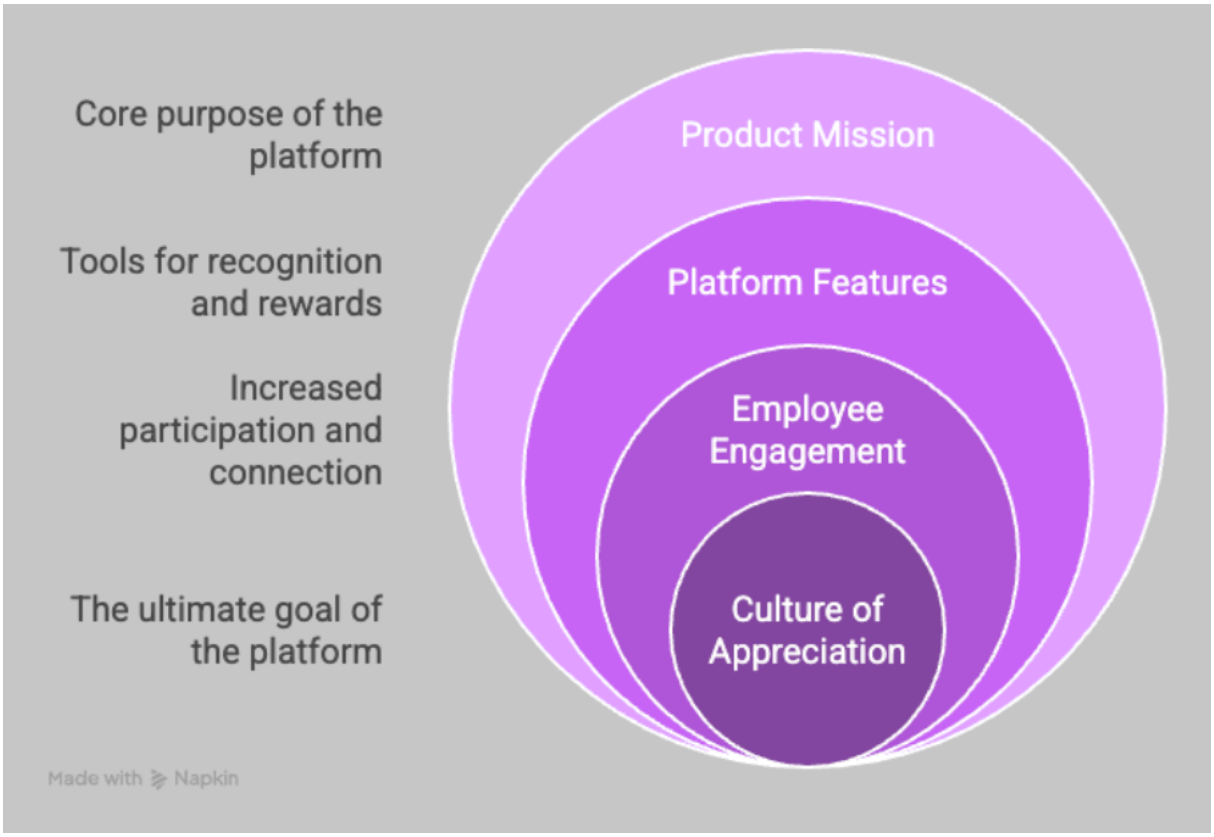
Implementing ongoing appreciation practices

Made with Napkin

C. Product Mission

Vantage Circle's Recognition & Rewards platform makes it easy and rewarding for employees and managers to recognize each other instantly, every day. By providing simple tools, smart reminders, and a visible company-wide feed, the platform turns appreciation into a continuous, engaging habit, helping organizations build a culture where everyone feels valued and connected.

To empower organizations to build a culture of appreciation by providing an intuitive platform for seamless, real-time, and socially visible employee recognition.



D. Problem Statement

Below is the problem statement that summarizes the core problem Vantage Circle's Recognition & Rewards platform is designed to solve:

"**When I** notice great work by my colleagues, **I want to** recognize them immediately and meaningfully, **but I struggle because** I often forget, don't know what to say, or don't see their achievements, **leading to** missed opportunities to motivate my team and build a strong, positive culture."

Problem-Solution Fit

In today's fast-paced organizations, consistent and meaningful employee recognition is often overlooked, despite its proven impact on motivation, engagement, and retention. Many companies still rely on outdated, infrequent, or offline recognition methods that fail to reinforce positive behaviours or foster a culture of appreciation.

As a result, employees may feel undervalued, achievements go unnoticed, and organizations miss out on the benefits of a truly engaged workforce.
Vantage Circle's proposed Rewards & Recognition platform is designed to address these challenges by making recognition timely, visible, and effortless.

ey Problems	**Why This Matters**	**he Proposed Solution Addresses This**
sistent nition	ased motivation and ement	ecognition/Smart nudges/templates for recognition
isibility	ns positive culture and	ny-wide feed for visible recognition
d Gratification	ns link between ement and reward	me, continuous recognition
f Structure	opportunities to motivate	structured platform for recognition

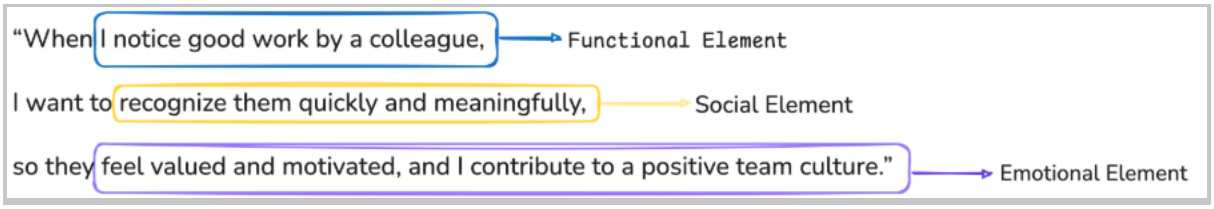
Note: The above problems and proposed solutions are based on secondary research, industry benchmarks, and insights from similar products in the market.

E. Jobs-To-Be-Done (JTBD)

Having established the core problems and how Vantage Circle aims to solve them, it's important to clarify the fundamental "job" that users are hiring the platform to do.
The below JTBD framework helps us focus on the real outcome users want, beyond just features, by identifying their core functional, emotional, and social needs:

Core JTBD Statement:

"**When I** notice good work by a colleague, **I want to** recognize them quickly and meaningfully, **so they** feel valued and motivated, and I contribute to a positive team culture."



F. User Research Plan

If we assume Vantage Circle's Recognition & Rewards platform is a proposed solution and not yet live, the problem validation is based on a combination of secondary research and proxy user insights:

Method	Approach	Key Insights
ry Reports	ved HR tech adoption studies and ned surveys on employee ition practices.	that inconsistent, infrequent, and ibility recognition is a widespread nge.
Interviews	with HR professionals and yees from similar organizations to tand their practices.	ned that forgetfulness, lack of tes, and delayed recognition are on barriers.
etitor sis	ed features and user feedback ading recognition platforms.	ed gaps in current solutions and ed the need for real-time, visible, o-use tools.

These methods validate that the problem of inconsistent and ineffective recognition is real and significant, providing a strong foundation for MVP design and prioritization.

G. Persona Snapshot

To ensure the platform addresses real user needs, here are three representative personas affected by the problem of inconsistent, low-visibility recognition in organizations:

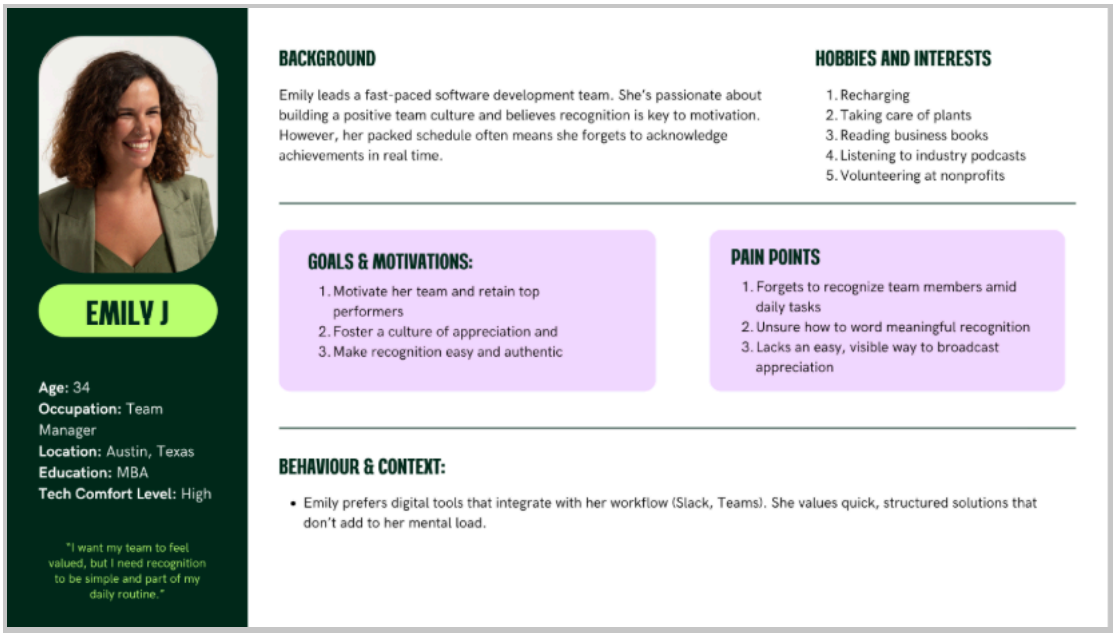


ame	Role	oals & Motivations	Pain Points	Quote
Johnson	Manager	te and retain team; a culture of iation	s to recognize; how to word ition	my team to feel , but I need ition to be simple and my daily routine.”
el Carter	ıre eer	ppreciated for daily get timely feedback	nition is rare/generic; visible outside big s	otivating to be ized for the small ot just the big es.”

Lee	ector	appreciation culture; ecognition trends	visibility into ition; hard to re impact	gnition should be ious and measurable, t an annual HR e.”

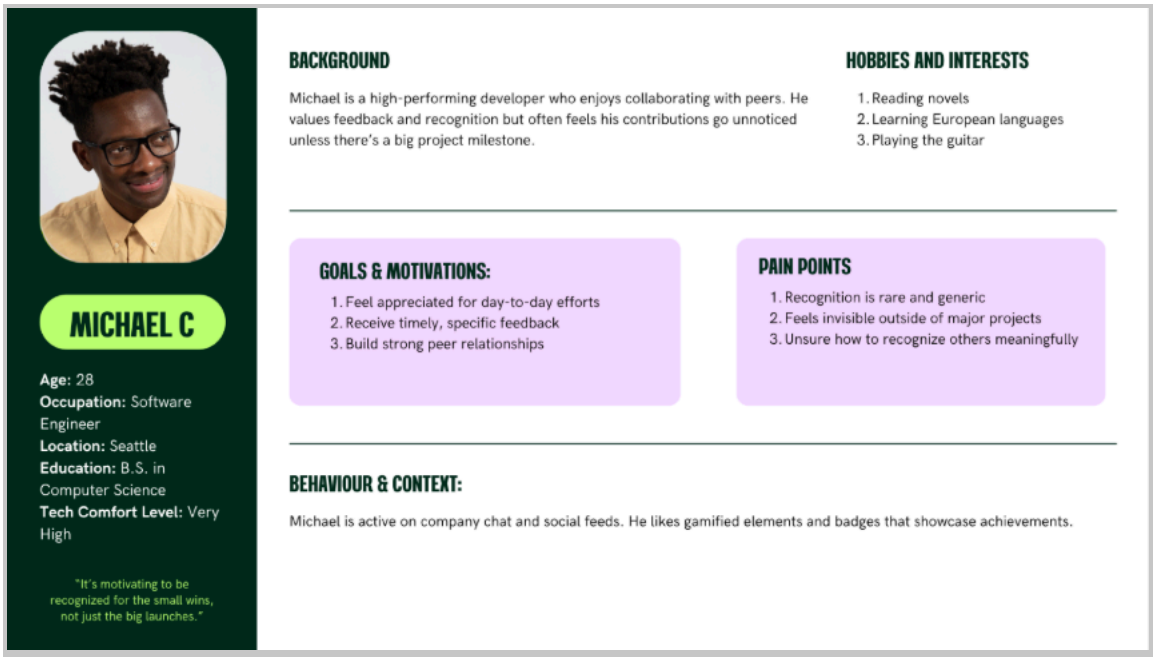
1. Emily Johnson

Age: 34 || **Occupation:** Team Manager, SaaS Company
Location: Austin, Texas || **Education:** MBA, University of Texas
Tech Comfort Level: High



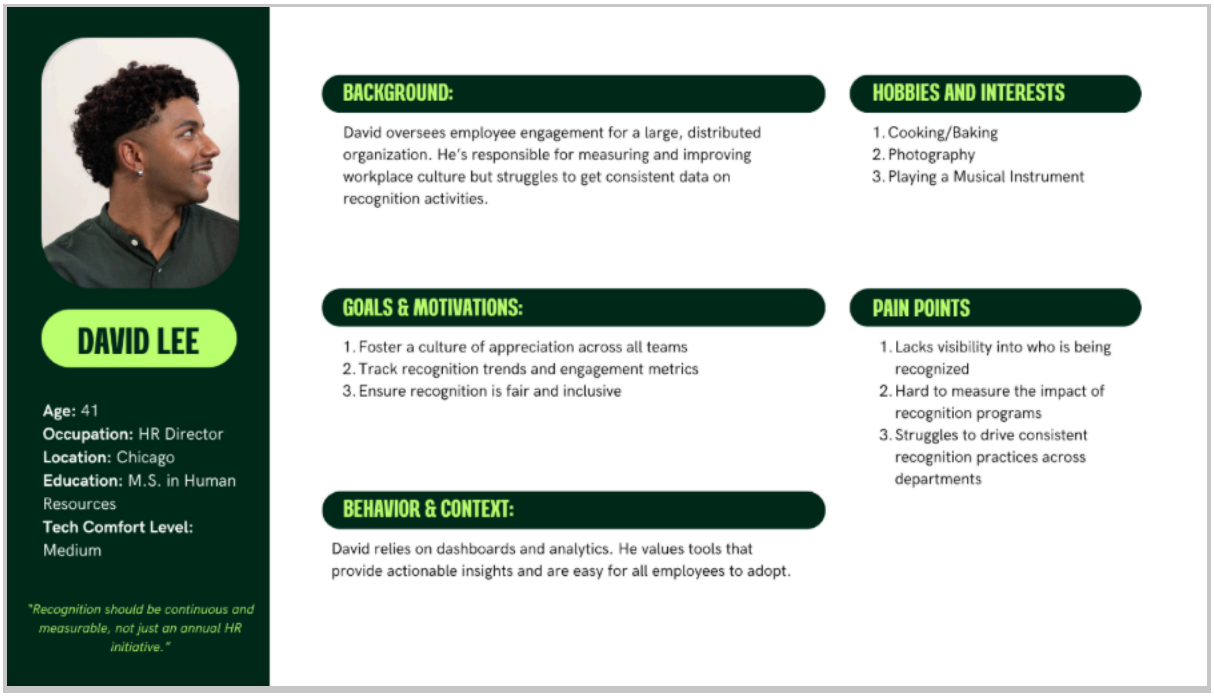
2. Michael Carter

Age: 28 || **Occupation:** Software Engineer
Location: Seattle, Washington || **Tech Comfort Level:** Very High
Education: B.S. in Computer Science, University of Washington



3. David Lee

Age: 41 || **Occupation:** HR Director
Location: Chicago, Illinois || **Tech Comfort Level:** Medium
Education: M.S. in Human Resources, Northwestern University

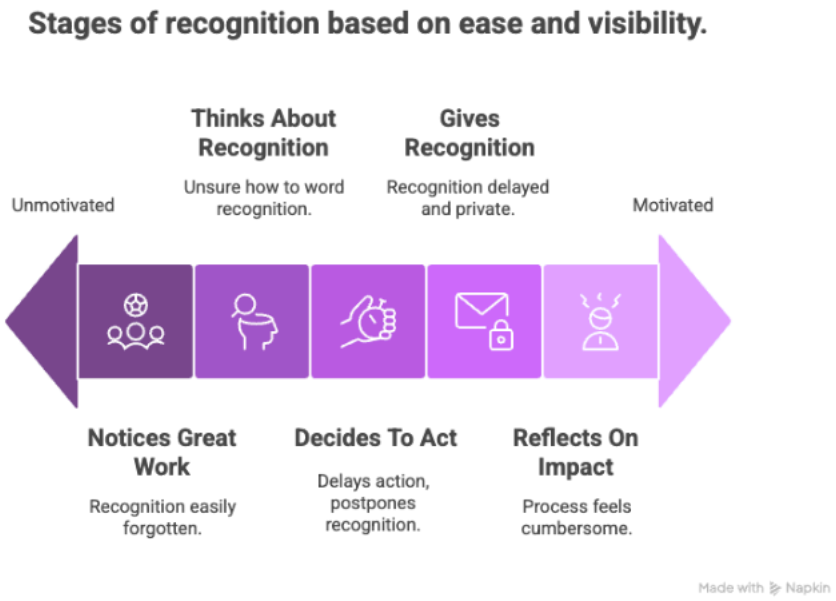


H. Customer Journey Map (CJM)

Here's the structure of CJM for the persona Emily Johnson (Team Manager), focusing on her journey with employee recognition before using Vantage Circle:

Customer Journey Map (CJM) – Emily Johnson (Team Manager)

Stage	mily Does / Experiences	Thoughts & Feelings	ain Points / Barriers
ess	team members doing ork	l recognize them, but I'm busy."	tion is not top-of-mind; rgotten
eration	about how and when to ze	I send a message or wait for the iew?"	how to word recognition; template
n	whether to act now or e	I'll do it later or during the y review."	action; often postpones ion
y & Use	ecognition via email or in a	inally did it, but was it gful?"	tion is delayed, private, or le to others
& Advocacy	on recognition process act	t was easier and more visible for n."	feels cumbersome; not ed to repeat



Summary:
Emily's current journey is full of friction and missed opportunities for meaningful, visible recognition. These pain points are precisely what the Vantage Circle platform is designed to solve, by making recognition timely, easy, and socially visible.

I. Opportunity Sizing

The need for better employee recognition is massive and growing. According to recent HR tech market reports, the global employee recognition software market is projected to reach $56.5 billion by 2030.

Table 1: Market Opportunity Summary

Market	Size (2030 est.)
Global Market	$56.5 Billion
India Market	$1.2 Billion

Target Segment:
Vantage Circle's platform is designed for mid-to-large private sector companies (1,000+ employees).

- Globally, this segment represents ~5,860 companies and ~29.3 million employees.
- In India, the addressable market includes 1,000 companies (mid/large) and 5.4 million employees.

Revenue Potential:

- ***Global addressable market (SAM):*** ~$2.1B annually (based on $6/employee/month SaaS pricing).
- ***India addressable market (SAM):*** $115M–$288M annually (based on $4–8/employee/month).

Table 2: Addressable Market (SAM) Summary

Market	**No. of Companies**	**No. of Employees**	**Annual Revenue Potential**
Global	~5,860	~29.3 million	~$2.1B
India	1,000	5.4 million	$115M – $288M

Note: *Over 70% of employees feel unrecognized at work as per HR industry studies.*

In summary:
This is a meaningful and urgent problem, affecting millions of employees and representing a multi-billion-dollar market opportunity. Addressing recognition gaps delivers real business value by improving retention, culture, and company performance.

J. Prioritization

Since the product is not yet live, I have prioritized features based on industry research, proxy user interviews, and competitor analysis. This approach helps us focus on the features most likely to solve the biggest pain points for our target users and deliver business value in our MVP.

To ensure we focus on the most impactful features for launch, I used the RICE framework (Reach, Impact, Confidence, Effort) to prioritize what should be included in Phase 1 (MVP) and what can be planned for Phase 2 (Post MVP).
(Note: All estimates are based on secondary data and expert judgment, as is standard practice in early-stage product management.)

Summary Table

Phase	Features	Timeline
Phase 1	• Easy search & select recognition • Org-wide feed visibility • Like & comment • Monetary & non-monetary recognition	**MVP**
Phase 2	• *Achievement badges & gamification* • *Smart nudges* • *Panel award* • *Analytics & Integrations with Slack/Teams*	*Post MVP (coming soon)*

Applying RICE to Our Features

Based on market research, proxy user interviews, and competitor analysis, I estimated the RICE scores for key features:

Feature	ach	pact	nfidence	ffort	CE Score
arch & select recognition	9	9	8	5	129.6
le feed visibility	9	8	8	5	115.2
comment on recognition posts	8	7	8	4	112
ry & non-monetary recognition options	7	8	7	5	78.4
ement badges & gamification	6	6	7	6	42
udges/reminders	7	7	6	7	42
wards/multi-level approvals	5	6	6	8	22.5
ed analytics & integrations	6	7	6	8	31.5

What This Means

Highest priority (Phase 1/MVP):
The features with the highest RICE scores: easy search & select, organization-wide feed, social interactions (like/comment), and monetary/non-monetary options, directly address the core pain points and are most likely to drive adoption and engagement.

Phase 2 (Post-MVP):
Features like badges, smart nudges, advanced analytics, and panel awards are valuable for deeper engagement and differentiation and can be developed after validating the MVP.

Conclusion

By applying the RICE framework, we objectively prioritize features that solve the most pressing user problems and deliver the most value with the resources available. This ensures a focused MVP and a clear roadmap for future growth, even before the product exists.

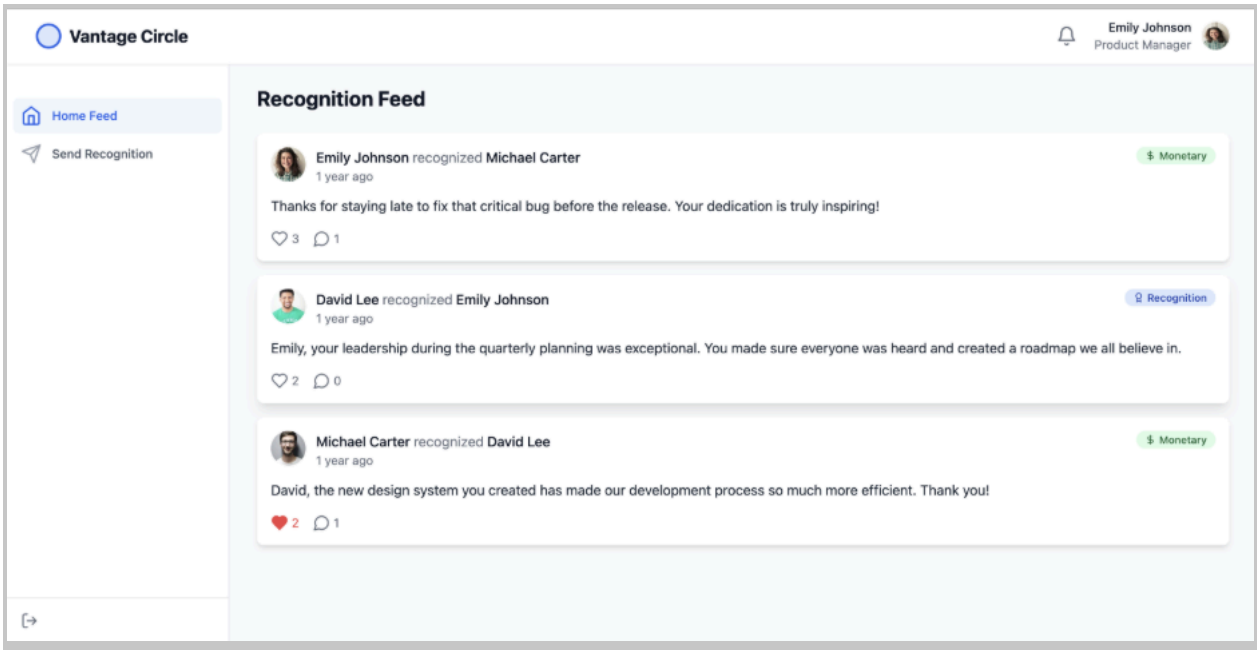
K. MVP Idea

The smallest possible solution (MVP) I would launch to test whether we're solving the recognition problem is:

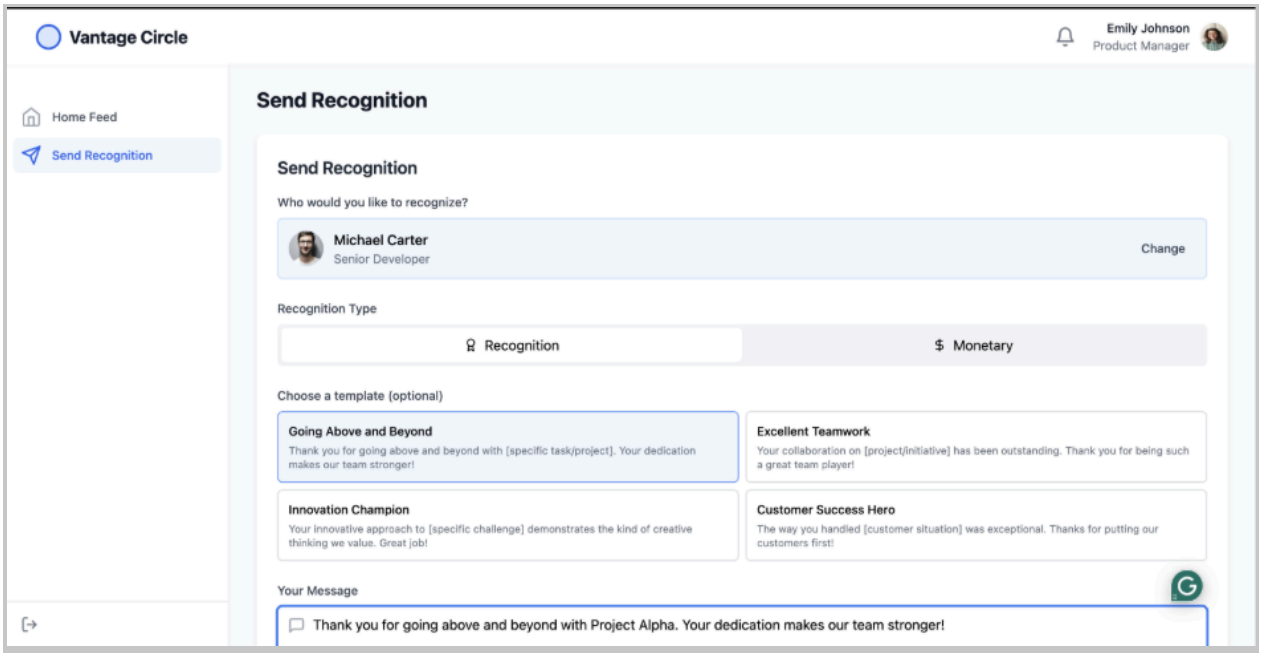
- A simple web-based platform where anyone in the organization can search for a colleague, select a recognition type (monetary or non-monetary), and post a recognition message.
- All recognition posts appear in a central, organization-wide feed, visible to everyone.
- Colleagues can like and comment on each recognition post.

This MVP directly addresses the core user pain points: making recognition easy, visible, and engaging. By launching with just these features, we can quickly validate if employees use the platform, if recognition becomes more frequent and visible, and if social interactions (likes/comments) drive engagement.

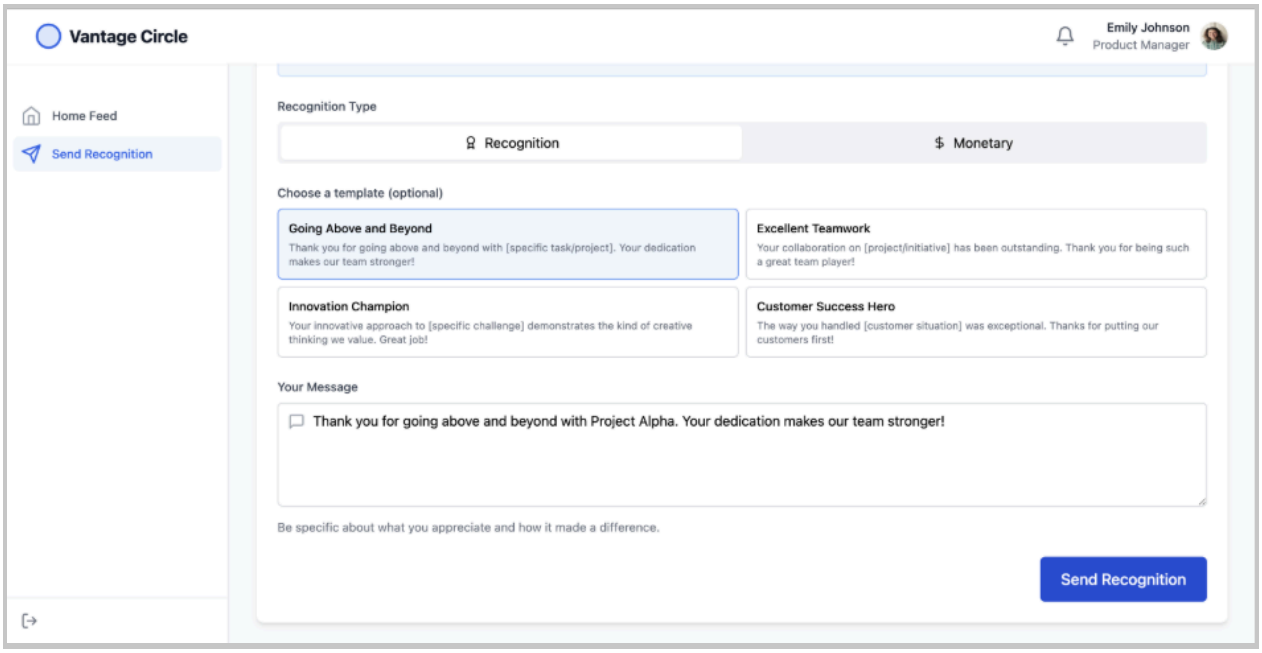
Sample Wireframes – MVP Flows for Recognition



Picture 1: (*Home Feed: All recognition posts appear in a central, organization-wide feed, visible to everyone also colleagues/seniors can like and comment on each recognition post)*



Picture 2: (*Send Recognition: where anyone in the organization can search for a colleague, select a recognition type (monetary or non-monetary), and post a recognition message.)*



L. Roadmap Format

Since the product is not yet live and priorities may evolve based on initial user feedback, I would use the Now–Next–Later roadmap format.

(Note: I feel this approach is well-suited because it emphasizes flexibility, focuses on immediate priorities, and avoids committing to specific deadlines before real-world validation.)

Breakdown of the Roadmap:

Now (MVP)	xt (Post-MVP Enhancements)	er (Advanced Features)
& select recognition	chievement badges & gamification	el awards/multi-level approvals
e feed visibility	Smart nudges/reminders	anced analytics & integrations
omment on posts	Simple analytics	-
y & non-monetary recognition	-	-

[**Note:**
Now → Features that are essential for the MVP launch and immediate validation of the core problem.
Next → Features to be developed soon after the MVP, based on user feedback and early adoption metrics.
Later → Advanced or differentiating features that will be considered after the core solution has proven successful.]

Why Now–Next–Later?

- It allows the team to stay focused on delivering and validating the core value proposition first.
- It provides stakeholders with a clear sense of direction without over-promising on timelines.
- It keeps the roadmap adaptable, so we can quickly respond to user needs and market changes as we learn from the MVP.

M. Bonus: AI Thinking

Going forward, we can implement AI to track user behaviour across the platform and provide personalized recommendations for recognition. By analyzing patterns such as work anniversaries, project completions, and peer interactions, AI can prompt managers and colleagues to recognize contributions that might otherwise be missed.